



The Person First Introduction Guide

How to Lead Every IEP Meeting by Introducing Your Child as a Person First

The Know Me Method

Because every child deserves to be known before they are evaluated.

A Method by Kimberly, Robbie's Mom and Founder of IEP Approved

The Philosophy

Before the goals. Before the data. Before the services. Before the diagnosis.

There is a child.

The Person First Introduction — the Know Me Method — is a technique developed through years of IEP meetings, trial and error, and a fundamental belief that the most effective advocacy begins not with legal language — but with humanity.

When every person in that room sees your child as a full human being first — funny, curious, stubborn, joyful, complicated, wonderful — the entire tone of the meeting shifts. The conversation becomes about building a future for a real kid, not managing a diagnosis.

The diagnosis is real. The challenges are real. The legal requirements are real. But none of that is the first thing the team needs to know about your child. You are.

Why This Works

It changes the frame

When you lead with who your child is as a person, you establish the lens through which everything else will be discussed. The team is no longer looking at a file — they are looking at a kid they now feel they know.

It humanizes you as a parent

Sharing something warm and real about your child signals that you are an engaged, loving parent. It makes it harder for anyone in that room to be dismissive or bureaucratic. You are not a complaint. You are a family.

It creates connection



Educators went into teaching because they care about children. When you give them something to connect to — a funny story, a proud moment, a glimpse of your child's personality — you activate that instinct. Suddenly they are rooting for your kid, not just managing them.

It anchors the meeting

Throughout the meeting, you can return to the person-first frame whenever things get tense. "That behavior you're describing — at home he does the same thing when he's proud of himself." You are always bringing them back to the child.

It is disarming

It is very hard to be adversarial with someone who just made you smile about their kid. Lead with warmth and you earn the room before the hard conversations begin.



THE IEP MOMMY METHOD — Step by Step

1

Send the Introduction Ahead of Time

One to two days before the meeting, email the team a brief introduction of your child. Not their IEP history. Not their challenges. Who they are.

- A few photos — at home, doing something they love, being a kid
- Their name (not "the student" — their name)
- 3-5 things they love: their favorite show, sport, food, hobby, joke
- 1-2 things they are proud of this year
- One thing you want the team to know about who your child is as a person

■ **Subject line: "A little about [NAME] before our meeting" — this sets the tone before anyone walks in the door.**

2

Open the Meeting with Your Child

When the meeting begins and introductions are done, before the team dives into data and goals, you speak first.

- "Before we get started, I'd like to take a few minutes to share a little about [NAME] — who he is beyond this IEP."
- Share 2-3 things that make your child who they are
- Tell one story — funny, proud, or heartwarming — from recent memory
- Show a photo if you did not send one ahead
- End with: "That's who we're here for today."

■ **Keep it to 3-5 minutes. You are not giving a speech — you are setting a frame. Brief, warm, and real.**



3

Pepper Person-First Moments Throughout

This is the technique that separates a good meeting from a great one. Throughout the meeting — especially when the conversation gets clinical or tense — bring the person back into the room.

How to use this in the meeting:

When they discuss a behavior:

"That actually makes me smile a little — he does the same thing at home when he's excited about something. What I've noticed is that it tends to happen when..."

When they present data or scores:

"Those numbers tell one piece of the story. What I'd add is that this year he [personal achievement]. The data doesn't capture that."

When there is disagreement:

"I want to get back to what we know about [NAME] as a person. What environment allows him to be his best self? That's what we're trying to build."

When discussing goals:

"The goal I most want to see for [NAME] this year is one that connects to who he is becoming — not just what he is struggling with."

When the meeting gets bureaucratic:

"Can we pause for a second? I want to make sure we are talking about a kid, not a checklist."

4

Close with the Person

At the end of the meeting, close the same way you opened — with your child.

- "Before we wrap up, I want to say thank you to this team. [NAME] is lucky to have people who care about him."
- Share one thing you are looking forward to for your child this year
- If appropriate, share something your child said about school or their teachers



- "That's who we built this IEP for today. I'm grateful."

■ **Closing with warmth — even after a difficult meeting — leaves the relationship intact. You will be back at this table. End in a way that makes them want to do right by your child.**



THE PRE-MEETING EMAIL TEMPLATE

Customize this and send it 1-2 days before every IEP meeting.

Subject: A little about [CHILD'S NAME] before our meeting

Hi [TEAM MEMBER NAMES or "IEP Team"],

I'm looking forward to our meeting on [DATE]. Before we get into the details of [NAME]'s IEP, I wanted to share a little about who he/she is as a person — because I think it helps to have that picture in mind as we talk.

[NAME] is [AGE] years old and in [GRADE] grade. Some things you might not know about him/her:

- [FAVORITE THING #1 — e.g., He is obsessed with dinosaurs and can name every species without blinking.]
- [FAVORITE THING #2 — e.g., She just learned to ride a bike and told everyone she saw for a week.]
- [PERSONALITY TRAIT — e.g., He has a sense of humor that catches adults off guard — in the best way.]
- [RECENT PROUD MOMENT — e.g., She performed in her school's talent show this year and did not miss a single beat.]

He/She [ONE THING ABOUT HOW YOUR CHILD EXPERIENCES SCHOOL].

I'm attaching a few photos so you can see the kid I'm talking about.

I'm looking forward to working with all of you to build something great for [NAME] this year.

See you [DAY],

[YOUR NAME]

Parent/Guardian of [CHILD'S NAME]

YOUR CHILD'S PERSON FIRST PROFILE

Fill this out before each school year. Update it as your child grows. This is the foundation of every Know Me Method introduction.

Child's full name (and what they like to be called):

Age, grade, and school:

3 things they love most in the world:



Their current favorite: show / movie / book / game:

Something they are really proud of this year:

A funny or heartwarming story from this year:

How they are doing socially — friendships, connections:

Something that surprised you about them this year:

What they want to be when they grow up:

One thing you wish every teacher knew about your child:

The most important thing we are working toward for them this year:

A quote or thing they said recently that captures who they are:

A Note From Kimberly

I started doing this with Robbie at our very first IEP meeting — before I knew it was a "method." It was just instinct. I knew that the people across the table needed to see my son before they could advocate for him. So I showed them.

I emailed pictures. I told the story about how he gives double thumbs up to everything he loves. I told them about the time he tried to give his teacher a high five and accidentally knocked her glasses off. I told them he was funny and stubborn and curious and kind.

And something shifted in the room. They laughed. They leaned in. They started the meeting already invested in a kid they felt like they knew.

When the hard conversations came — and they always come — I kept bringing Robbie back into the room. "That behavior you're describing? He does that at home when he's excited about something. Let me tell you what I've noticed..." Every time I did it, the conversation got warmer. More human. More productive.



The IEP process is legal. It is structured. It can feel cold and clinical and exhausting. But at the center of it is a child. Your child. The most important thing you can do is make sure everyone in that room never forgets that.

Lead with your child. Always. That's the Know Me Method.

— *Kimberly, Robbie's Mom and Founder of IEP Approved*